

MARIZA LAKMINI SHEHARA COORAY

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EDUCATION

Yale University, New Haven, CT

Aug '26 – May '27

M.A. International and Development Economics (tuition scholarship)

Graduate coursework in progress: ECON 545 Microeconomics; ECON 546 Macroeconomics; ECON 558 Econometrics; ECON 724 International Finance.

Research interests: economic inequality, spatial economics, international trade

Australian National University, Canberra, ACT

Feb '21 – Dec '22

Postgraduate Certificate in Mathematics. GPA 6.75/7.00. 90% Commonwealth tuition grant, awarded on academic performance.

Metric Spaces (Highest Honours); Mathematical Thinking (Highest Honours); Multivariable Calculus and Linear Algebra (Highest Honours); Probability Theory (Honours).

London School of Economics and Political Science, London, UK

Oct '10 – Aug '11

M.Sc. Development Studies (Merit). PJD Wiles / Abraaj Capital Postgraduate Fellowship.

Dissertation: *Examining Intra-Household Bargaining Power: An Explanation of Capital Flight as a Result of Spousal Control*.

Published by Abraaj Capital, Dubai, 2012.

Wilson College, Chambersburg, PA

Sep '06 – Aug '10

B.A. (Honours) Economics, magna cum laude. GPA 3.79/4.00. Full scholarship.

Thesis (university thesis prize): *The Impact of Received Remittances on Savings Behaviour: An Inquiry into the Savings of Microloan Borrowers Using Experimental Methods*. Finalist, best undergraduate paper competition, Midwestern Economics Association, 2010.

Honours: Phi Beta Kappa; Pi Gamma Mu; William P. Van Looy Business and Economics Prize (2010); Strait Prize, highest-ranking student in Political Science and International Relations (2010); Margaret Criswell Disert Scholarship for the best honours research proposal (2009).

Exchange and fellowships: undergraduate exchange in Economics, King's College, University of Cambridge (merit tuition waiver; Isaac Newton Trust grant, 2009); School of International Studies, Peking University (merit scholarship, Spring '08); Kathryn Davis Global Fellowship for Peace, Middlebury College (2010).

WORKING PAPERS

Tracking the Hidden Forces Behind Laos' 2022 Exchange Rate Crisis and Balance of Payments Instability (with Rolando Gonzales Martinez). arXiv:2503.13308 [econ.EM], March 2025. Uses a dynamic factor model to identify the latent drivers of the kip's depreciation and Laos' balance-of-payments instability.

Enhancing Poverty Targeting with Spatial Machine Learning: An Application to Indonesia (with Rolando Gonzales Martinez). arXiv:2503.04300 [econ.EM], March 2025; also on SSRN. Adds spatial contiguity to proxy means testing using DTKS household data (2016–21); cuts exclusion errors from 28 to 20 per cent relative to standard machine learning models.

RESEARCH AND ADVISORY EXPERIENCE

Asian Development Bank, Senior Economist, Sydney, Australia

Feb '26 – present

- Lead modeller for GDP nowcasting across the South Pacific using large data sources, including ports data.
- Built and maintain a four-layer nowcasting framework for Tonga, Fiji and Samoa: Denton temporal disaggregation, a weighted composite indicator, an ARDL bridge equation, and rolling annual aggregation with ETS confidence bands.
- Draft Asian Development Outlook country chapters and debt sustainability analysis annexes for selected economies.
- Quantified the impact of the oil price shock on industries in small island economies; internal paper circulated.

Asian Development Bank, Senior Macroeconomic Adviser to the PNG Treasury, Port Moresby, PNG

Apr '24 – Dec '25

- Built a new CPI forecasting model for the Department of Treasury; built an export-import index and updated the REER and NEER forecasting models.
- Produced quarterly kina–AUD and kina–USD forecasts using variance decomposition analysis; briefed the Minister on them.
- Advised the Treasurer and the Bank of Papua New Guinea on the de facto crawl-like adjustment of the kina.
- Advised the National Statistics Office on CPI weights.

Lowy Institute, Indo-Pacific Development Centre, Senior Economist / Research Fellow, Sydney

Jan '23 – Jan '25

- Senior adviser to the Australian Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade on the sovereign debt crises in Laos and Sri Lanka.
- Estimated a Bayesian VAR and a dynamic factor model for a sovereign debt paper on Laos.
- Led on Stata analysis for the Centre, particularly on international trade related to Indonesia and Australia.
- Authored Interpreter articles on sovereign debt restructuring and international finance.

Inclusive Economics Pty. Ltd., Principal Economist (self-employed), Canberra

Mar '15 – present

Concurrent short-term engagements:

- Social protection financing adviser to the Pacific, Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, 2023–24.

- Team Leader, Improving Pacific Public Financial Management facility, Asian Development Bank, Jan '21 – Aug '22.
- Senior Economist and machine learning specialist (social protection), TNP2K (National Team for the Acceleration of Poverty Reduction), Office of the Vice-President of Indonesia, Dec '20 – Dec '22.
- Macroeconomic consultant, Office of the Chief Economist, Australian Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, May '21 – Nov '21.
- Macroeconomic Adviser, Ministry of Finance and Treasury, Solomon Islands, Jun '19 – Oct '20 (DFAT funded).
- Macroeconomic Adviser, Ministry of Finance and Economic Management, Cook Islands, 2018 (NZ Government funded).
- Fiscal Economic Adviser, Government of Papua New Guinea, 2016–17 (Australian Government funded).
- Country Economist, Macroeconomics, Trade and Investment, World Bank, South Asia, 2017–18.
- Economist, Health, Nutrition and Population, World Bank, Papua New Guinea, 2015–16.

Research assistant positions

- Queensland University of Technology, Brisbane (Sep '12 – Aug '13). Research assistant to Prof. Chris Eves on an Australian Research Council-funded study forecasting Australian natural resource prices.
- London School of Economics / University of Peradeniya (Oct '10 – Aug '11). PJD Wiles Fellow. Fieldwork and data analysis on intra-household bargaining, extending de Mel, McKenzie and Woodruff (2009), *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, 1(3): 1–32.
- University of Cambridge, Department of Economics (Dec '10 – Jan '11). Research assistant to Prof. Kumar Aniket on an Isaac Newton Trust-supported study of group borrowing in microfinance; developed the methodological design and tested it in z-Tree.
- Wilson College, Department of Economics (Sep '06 – May '10). Research assistant to Prof. Abdolreza Banan on the political economy of Iran; tutored undergraduates in intermediate macroeconomic and microeconomic theory.
- Earlier research assistant roles in Colombo, Sri Lanka (2005–08): Institute of Policy Studies (commodity price modelling); Social Policy Analysis Research Centre, University of Colombo; Secretariat for Coordinating the Peace Process; Centre for Policy Alternatives.

Other experience: Monitoring and Evaluation Specialist, Abt Associates, Brisbane (Aug '13 – Apr '15); Tax Economist, Michael Johnson Associates, Sydney (Sep '12 – Aug '13); Monitoring and Evaluation Officer, International Alert, London (Dec '11 – Jul '12).

SKILLS

Programming: Python, Stata, R.

Methods: Bayesian VARs, dynamic factor models, ARDL and bridge equations, VECM, SVARs, Denton temporal disaggregation, synthetic and counterfactual designs, spatial machine learning.

Software: Tableau, z-Tree, Microsoft Office (Excel, Word, PowerPoint).

Languages: English (fluent), Sinhala, Spanish, Mandarin, Indonesian, French, Tok Pisin.

PUBLICATIONS AND POLICY WRITING

Singh, R., D. Gandon and M. Cooray (2014). Perceptions and Applications of Monitoring and Evaluation in the Fiji Ministry of Health: 2009–2014. *Fiji Journal of Public Health*, 3(1): 49–53.

Barney, K., R. Rajah and M. Cooray (2025). *Trapped in Debt: China's Role in Laos' Economic Crisis*. Lowy Institute Analysis paper.

Dienier, F. and M. Cooray (2017). *Between the Lines: An Analysis of Sub-national Expenditure in Papua New Guinea*. National Economic and Fiscal Commission, Port Moresby.

Cooray, M. (2016). *Game Changer: Sub-national Expenditure in Papua New Guinea*. National Economic and Fiscal Commission, Port Moresby.

Five Lowy Institute Interpreter articles on sovereign debt in Sri Lanka and Laos (2023), including *The G-20's Approach on Debt has Failed* (with R. Walker) and *Sri Lanka's Deep Debt Bind* (with R. Rajah).

REFERENCES

Prof. Michael Boozar, Director, International Development Economics program, Yale University. Michael.boozar@yale.edu

Prof. Tim Forsyth, Chair, Department of International Development, London School of Economics and Political Science. t.j.forsyth@lse.ac.uk

Prof. Griff Ware, Mathematical Sciences Institute, Australian National University. griffith.ware@anu.edu.au